Vacancy Atlas

Vacancy Atlas: Executive Summary

Problem

Small cities face a difficult problem when they try to revitalize their downtowns and neighborhoods. They often do not know how many storefronts and homes are actually vacant, or where the vacancies are concentrated. Without that information, it is hard to decide where to spend limited revitalization funds. A planner in a small city may rely on a windshield survey done by an intern, a list from the assessor that is a year or two old, or the personal knowledge of a long-serving staff member. These approaches are slow, expensive in staff time, and inconsistent from one year to the next.

The stakes are real. Federal and state programs, as well as private foundations, offer funding for revitalization, but most of them ask applicants to show need with data. Cities that cannot document their vacancy levels are at a disadvantage when applying. Cities that do receive funds often cannot show afterward whether the money made a difference, because they never had a baseline.

Solution

Vacancy Atlas is a data product that estimates vacant storefronts and homes by cross-referencing two kinds of signals: utility activity and mail-delivery status. When a property has had no active utility account or very low usage for an extended period, and mail-delivery records flag it as undeliverable or vacant, the likelihood that it is empty is high. Neither signal is perfect alone, but together they give a more reliable picture than either one. Our software combines them, assigns each property a vacancy likelihood score, and displays the results on an easy-to-read map with block-level summaries.

The output is designed for non-technical users. A planner can open the map, filter by neighborhood or property type, and export a list for grant applications or field verification. We also provide a short quarterly update so that cities can track change over time.

Market

Our target customers are municipal planning and economic development offices in small and mid-sized cities, which we define as roughly 20,000 to 150,000 residents. In the United States there are several hundred such cities in the regions where we plan to start. We also see regional planning councils, downtown development authorities, and community development nonprofits as possible buyers. Many of these organizations manage grant programs and need data to decide where to send funds.

We estimate that if we reach a modest share of these organizations at an annual price in the low thousands of dollars each, the market is large enough to support a small company. We recognize that this estimate is rough and that municipal budgets are tight. We plan to refine it through conversations with pilot customers.

Business Model

We plan to sell annual subscriptions. The base subscription would include access to the vacancy map, a yearly data refresh, and exports. A higher tier would add quarterly updates and help with grant applications. We expect pricing to depend on the size of the city. Early pilots may be offered at a discount or free in exchange for feedback and permission to describe results.

Our costs are mainly data acquisition, cloud hosting, and the time of the founders. The biggest uncertainty is access to the underlying data. We are exploring agreements with utility providers and using publicly available delivery-status information, and we are working through what privacy rules require. We believe that aggregating to the property level without personal information keeps us on safe ground, but we plan to get legal advice before expanding.

Competition

The space is crowded. Large data companies sell property and demographic data to cities, and some include vacancy indicators. Several software firms offer planning and permitting platforms that touch on vacancy. Some cities build their own tools using in-house analysts or university partners, and many simply use spreadsheets and field surveys. Our advantage is that we focus only on vacancy and design for small cities that cannot afford large platforms or dedicated data staff. Our use of utility and mail signals is not unique in principle, but we believe our focus on simplicity, price, and small-city needs gives us a place in the market. We know that larger competitors could add similar features, and we will need to move quickly to build relationships.

Team

Marcus Delgado leads product and customer relations. He is studying urban planning at our university and has worked part time in a city planning office, where he saw the vacancy problem firsthand. Priya Raman is responsible for data and modeling. She studies statistics and built the first version of our scoring approach. Tobias Lindqvist handles software development and the map interface; he is a computer science student with experience building web applications. Together we cover planning knowledge, data analysis, and engineering. We do not yet have a team member with sales experience, and we plan to look for advisors who do.

Milestones and Financials

So far we have defined the core concept, built a working prototype, and registered Vacancy Atlas LLC. The prototype has been shown to a small number of outside users, including staff at two city offices and a regional planning group, who gave us feedback on the map and the scoring. They said the idea was useful, though we do not yet have paying customers or signed pilot agreements. We also have a website that explains the product.

Our financial position is early. We have spent only small amounts of our own money on hosting and legal filing. We have not yet generated revenue. Our rough plan is to sign three to five pilot cities in the next year, convert some of them to paid subscriptions, and reach modest revenue that covers data and hosting costs by the end of the second year. These projections are based on assumptions that we have not fully tested, especially the price municipalities are willing to pay and how quickly they make purchasing decisions.

What We Are Asking For

We are applying to the competition for three things. First, funding to cover data costs, hosting, and legal advice on data privacy. Second, mentorship from people with experience selling to local governments, since this is the area where our team is weakest. Third, introductions to potential pilot cities and data partners. A prize would let us run our first formal pilots and test whether cities will pay for the product. We are open to feedback on our model and willing to adjust our approach based on what we learn.